

03

The Classical System Repertoire Map

Navigate 5.Nf3, 6.Be2, and the major seventh-move choices



THIS VOLUME

6

deep lessons

12

lesson positions

30

course pages

Build a coherent main-line repertoire around ...e5 while recognizing exits and transpositions.

LEARN THE STRUCTURE, THEN THE LINE

A four-pass method for a theory-heavy opening

1. DECODE THE POSITION

Read the board before the moves. Name the center, each side's break, the worst piece, the king-safety difference, and the race clock.

2. UNDERSTAND THE CAUSAL CHAIN

Every recommendation connects a cue to a reason and a consequence. If you know only the move, you do not yet know the opening.

3. PLAY THE DECISION

Generate Black's candidates, find White's strongest reply, and choose the resulting structure you understand. The move is the end of the reasoning, not the beginning.

4. RETRIEVE UNDER PRESSURE

Cover the answer key, reconstruct the line, and speak the memory rule. Review after 1, 3, 7, 14, and 30 days, then test the idea in a slow game.

THEORY WARNING

This is a durable concept-first repertoire, not a claim to be a live engine database. Before tournament use, verify sharp forcing branches in Fritz or a current database.

Priority order at the board: legality and tactical survival, king safety, forcing moves, central transformation, activity, structure, then the remembered rule.

SIX LINKED LESSONS

Recognition first, execution second

LESSON 013 | PAGE 4

Decode: Main-line entry

The branch is identified by White's first queenside commitment.

LESSON 014 | PAGE 8

Play: Main-line entry

The branch is identified by White's first queenside commitment.

LESSON 015 | PAGE 12

Decode: The quieter Orthodox route

A move order is a package of piece routes, not a cosmetic choice.

LESSON 016 | PAGE 16

Play: The quieter Orthodox route

A move order is a package of piece routes, not a cosmetic choice.

LESSON 017 | PAGE 20

Decode: Gligoric's Be3 question

A tempo gain is real only when the pawn weaknesses are affordable.

LESSON 018 | PAGE 24

Play: Gligoric's Be3 question

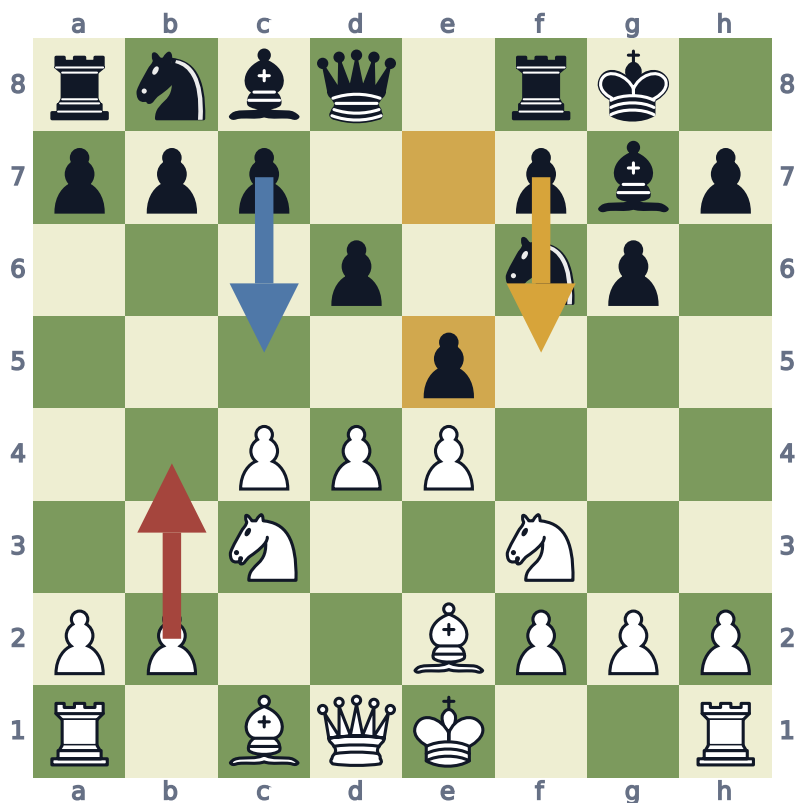
A tempo gain is real only when the pawn weaknesses are affordable.

VOLUME OBJECTIVE

Build a coherent main-line repertoire around ...e5 while recognizing exits and transpositions.

DECODE PASS | STRUCTURAL DECISION POINT

Decode: Main-line entry



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

This move order reaches the main closed center with maximum pressure on d4 and a clear division of wings.

DECISION RULE

On move nine identify White's setup before choosing ...Nd7, ...Nh5, ...a5, or another preparation.

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S JOB

Prepare the knight route and ...f5 while monitoring White's c5 and b4 timing.

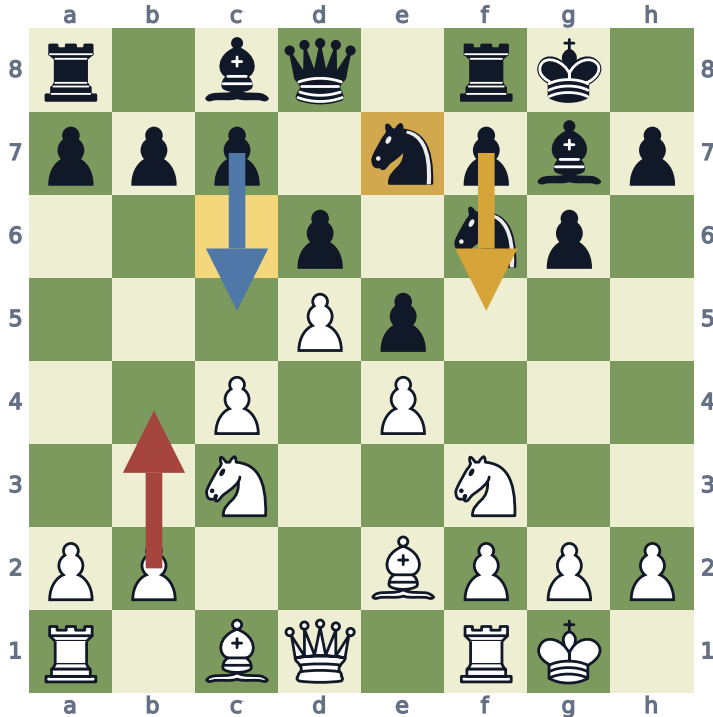
WHITE'S COUNTERPLAY

White chooses among Ne1, Nd2, b4, Bg5, or a4 to accelerate queenside play.

MEMORY RULE | The branch is identified by White's first queenside commitment.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

This move order reaches the main closed center with maximum pressure on d4 and a clear division of wings.

BLACK AIMS FOR

Prepare the knight route and ...f5 while monitoring White's c5 and b4 timing.

FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

White

WHITE'S BEST PRACTICAL IDEA

White chooses among Ne1, Nd2, b4, Bg5, or a4 to accelerate queenside play.

FAILURE MODE

Treating all ninth moves alike loses vital tempi in a race.

DECISION TEST

Ask: On move nine identify White's setup before choosing ...Nd7, ...Nh5, ...a5, or another preparation. Then compare at least two candidates against White's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

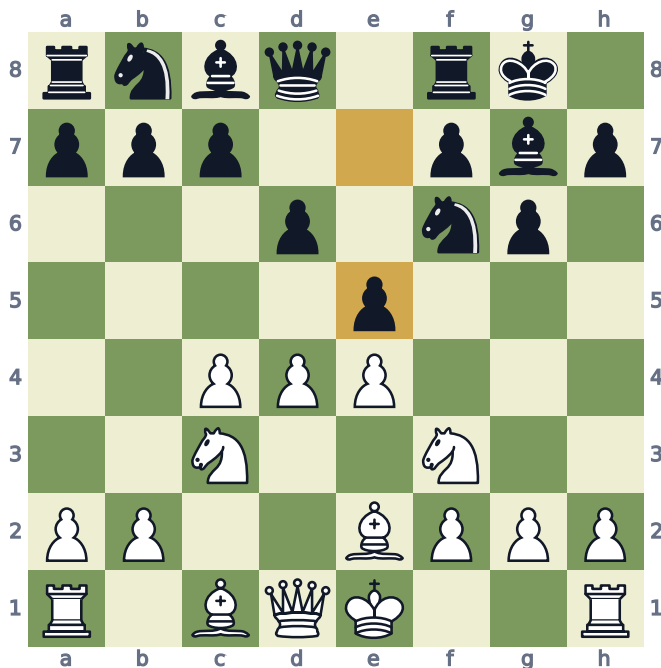
RULE | The branch is identified by White's first queenside commitment.

INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 g6 3. Nc3 Bg7 4. e4 d6 5. Nf3 O-O 6. Be2 e5 7. O-O Nc6 8. d5 Ne7



- e4: White changes the pawn skeleton; reassess breaks, open lines, and weakened squares.
- d6: Black changes the pawn skeleton; reassess breaks, open lines, and weakened squares.
- Nf3: White reroutes a knight toward f3; judge the move by its next square and immediate job.
- O-O: Black secures the king and activates a rook; the central decision can now become concrete.
- Be2: White changes a bishop's diagonal and the balance between development, pressure, and tempo.
- e5: Black makes direct central contact and asks whether White will close, capture, or maintain tension.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

This move order reaches the main closed center with maximum pressure on d4 and a clear division of wings.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

On move nine identify White's setup before choosing ...Nd7, ...Nh5, ...a5, or another preparation. White's resistance is: White chooses among Ne1, Nd2, b4, Bg5, or a4 to accelerate queenside play. The line fails as a template when: Treating all ninth moves alike loses vital tempi in a race.

STORE THIS | The branch is identified by White's first queenside commitment.

COVER THE ANSWER KEY AND SPEAK EACH ANSWER

Retrieval and self-coaching

1. What center or structural transition defines this position?

2. What is Black's primary plan, and which piece or pawn enables it?

3. What is White's fastest or most forcing counterplay?

4. What exact question decides the next move?

5. What is the most dangerous way to misuse the remembered plan?

ANSWER KEY

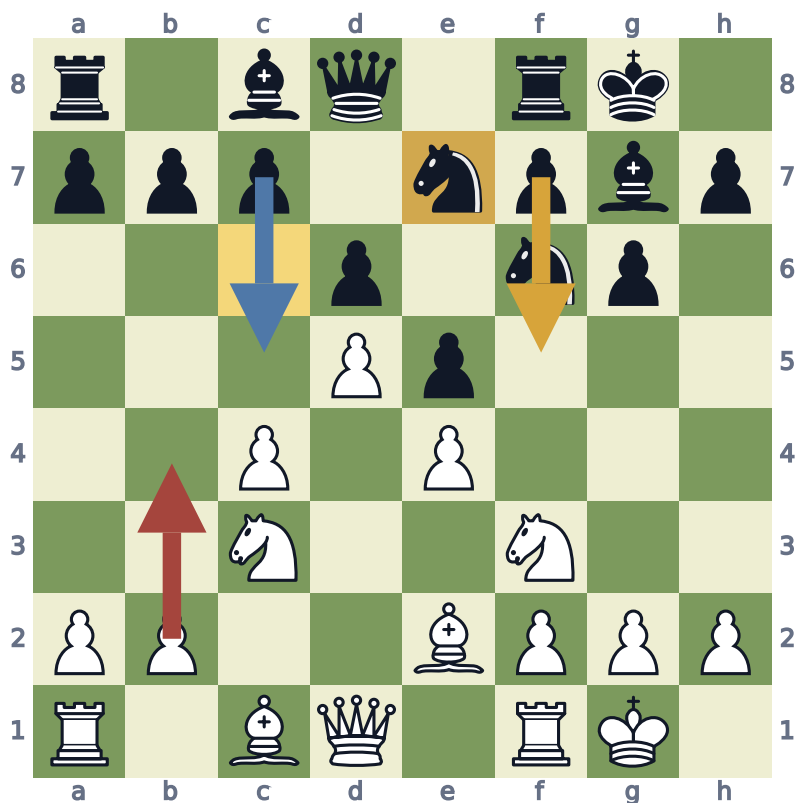
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BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 12 plies from memory, then replay: 4. e4 d6 5. Nf3 O-O 6. Be2 e5

PLAY PASS | PLAN EXECUTION AND TACTICAL CONTACT

Play: Main-line entry



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

This move order reaches the main closed center with maximum pressure on d4 and a clear division of wings.

DECISION RULE

On move nine identify White's setup before choosing ...Nd7, ...Nh5, ...a5, or another preparation.

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S JOB

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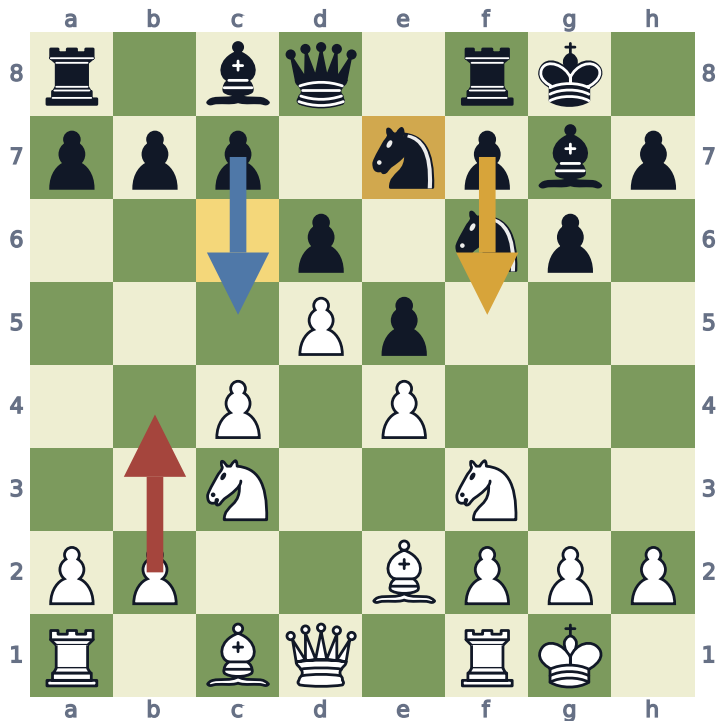
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CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

This move order reaches the main closed center with maximum pressure on d4 and a clear division of wings.

BLACK AIMS FOR

Prepare the knight route and ...f5 while monitoring White's c5 and b4 timing.

FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

White

WHITE'S BEST PRACTICAL IDEA

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Treating all ninth moves alike loses vital tempi in a race.

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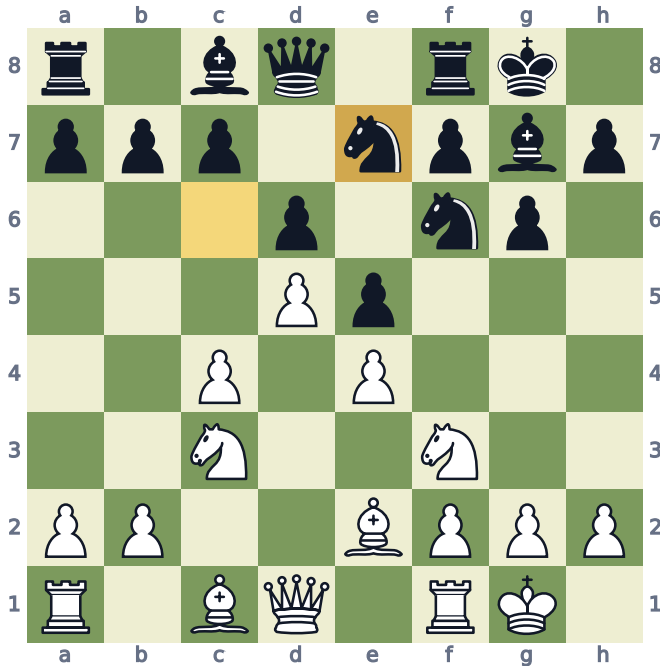
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INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 g6 3. Nc3 Bg7 4. e4 d6 5. Nf3 O-O 6. Be2 e5 7. O-O Nc6 8. d5 Ne7



- Be2: White changes a bishop's diagonal and the balance between development, pressure, and tempo.
- e5: Black makes direct central contact and asks whether White will close, capture, or maintain tension.
- O-O: White secures the king and activates a rook; the central decision can now become concrete.
- Nc6: Black reroutes a knight toward c6; judge the move by its next square and immediate job.
- d5: White claims space or creates a break that changes Black's available time and squares.
- Ne7: Black reroutes a knight toward e7; judge the move by its next square and immediate job.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

This move order reaches the main closed center with maximum pressure on d4 and a clear division of wings.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

On move nine identify White's setup before choosing ...Nd7, ...Nh5, ...a5, or another preparation. White's resistance is: White chooses among Ne1, Nd2, b4, Bg5, or a4 to accelerate queenside play. The line fails as a template when: Treating all ninth moves alike loses vital tempi in a race.

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COVER THE ANSWER KEY AND SPEAK EACH ANSWER

Retrieval and self-coaching

1. What center or structural transition defines this position?

2. What is Black's primary plan, and which piece or pawn enables it?

3. What is White's fastest or most forcing counterplay?

4. What exact question decides the next move?

5. What is the most dangerous way to misuse the remembered plan?

ANSWER KEY

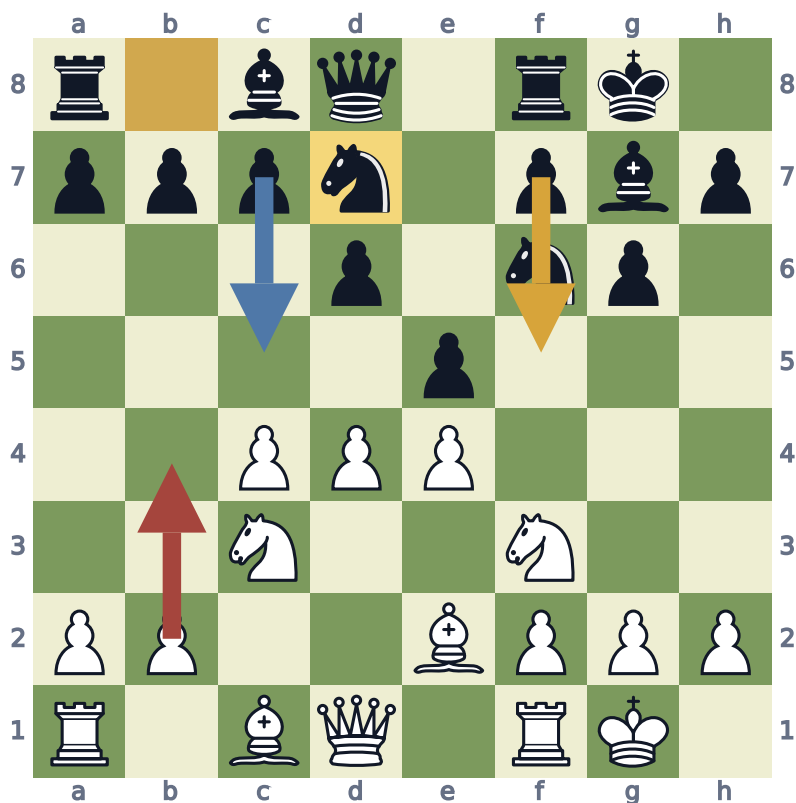
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BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 16 plies from memory, then replay: 6. Be2 e5 7. O-O Nc6 8. d5 Ne7

DECODE PASS | STRUCTURAL DECISION POINT

Decode: The quieter Orthodox route



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

...Nbd7 avoids an immediate commitment of the queen knight and supports ...c6, though it gives different pressure than ...Nc6.

DECISION RULE

Compare the benefits of ...Nc6 pressure with ...Nbd7 flexibility before selecting a repertoire branch.

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S JOB

Prepare a central challenge and keep the rook useful on e8.

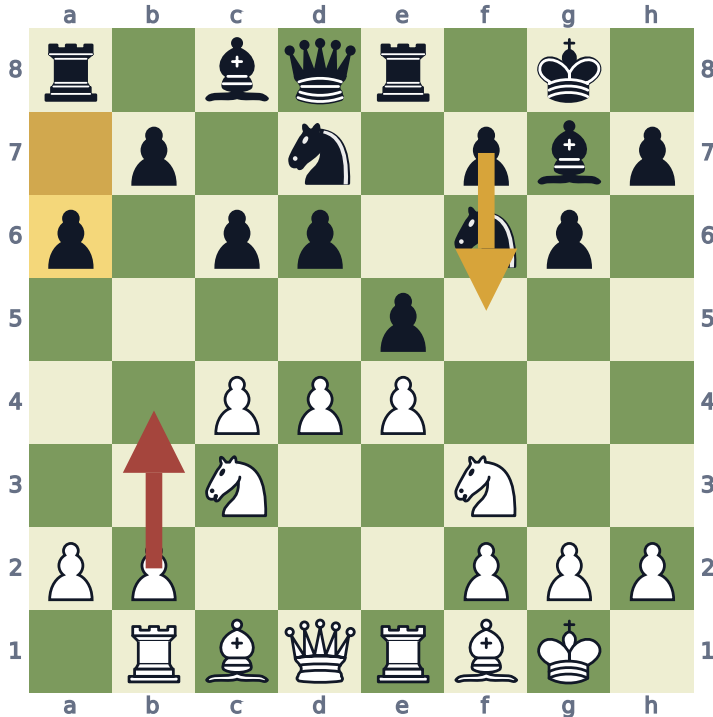
WHITE'S COUNTERPLAY

White gains space, supports b4, and may keep the center fluid.

MEMORY RULE | A move order is a package of piece routes, not a cosmetic choice.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

...Nbd7 avoids an immediate commitment of the queen knight and supports ...c6, though it gives different pressure than ...Nc6.

BLACK AIMS FOR

Prepare a central challenge and keep the rook useful on e8.

FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

White

WHITE'S BEST PRACTICAL IDEA

White gains space, supports b4, and may keep the center fluid.

FAILURE MODE

Mixing the plans can place both knights on passive squares.

DECISION TEST

Ask: Compare the benefits of ...Nc6 pressure with ...Nbd7 flexibility before selecting a repertoire branch. Then compare at least two candidates against White's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

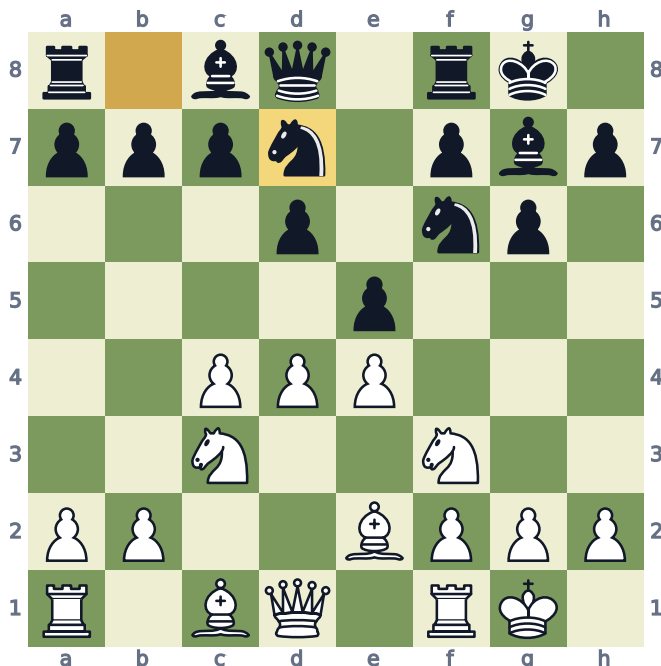
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INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 g6 3. Nc3 Bg7 4. e4 d6 5. Nf3 O-O 6. Be2 e5 7. O-O Nbd7 8. Re1 c6 9. Bf1 Re8 10. Rb1 a6



- Nf3: White reroutes a knight toward f3; judge the move by its next square and immediate job.
- O-O: Black secures the king and activates a rook; the central decision can now become concrete.
- Be2: White changes a bishop's diagonal and the balance between development, pressure, and tempo.
- e5: Black makes direct central contact and asks whether White will close, capture, or maintain tension.
- O-O: White secures the king and activates a rook; the central decision can now become concrete.
- Nbd7: Black reroutes a knight toward d7; judge the move by its next square and immediate job.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

...Nbd7 avoids an immediate commitment of the queen knight and supports ...c6, though it gives different pressure than ...Nc6.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

Compare the benefits of ...Nc6 pressure with ...Nbd7 flexibility before selecting a repertoire branch. White's resistance is: White gains space, supports b4, and may keep the center fluid. The line fails as a template when: Mixing the plans can place both knights on passive squares.

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COVER THE ANSWER KEY AND SPEAK EACH ANSWER

Retrieval and self-coaching

1. What center or structural transition defines this position?

2. What is Black's primary plan, and which piece or pawn enables it?

3. What is White's fastest or most forcing counterplay?

4. What exact question decides the next move?

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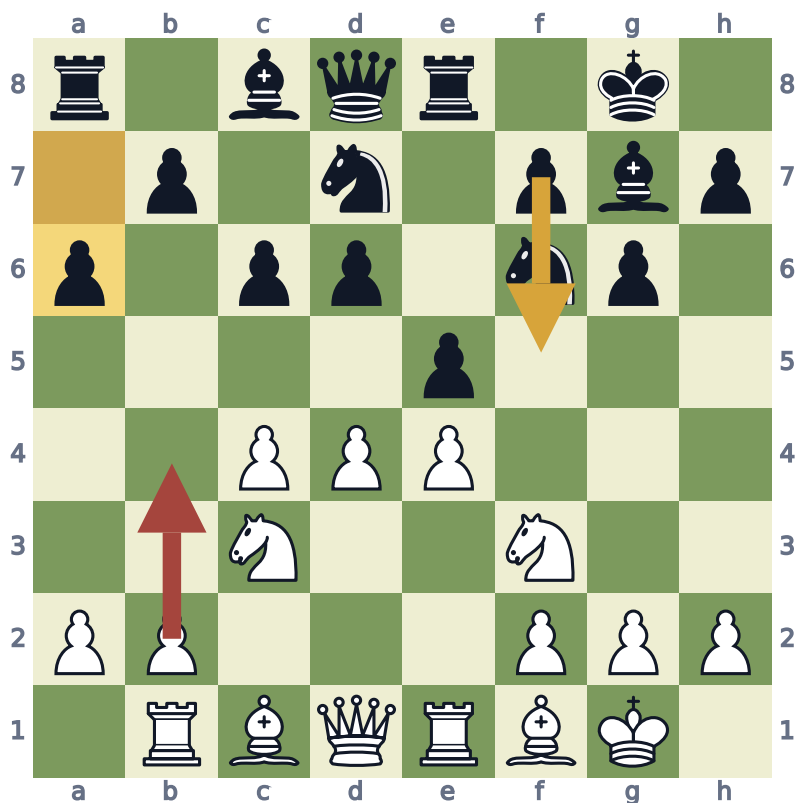
1. ...Nbd7 avoids an immediate commitment of the queen knight and supports ...c6, though it gives different pressure than ...Nc6. 2. Prepare a central challenge and keep the rook useful on e8. 3. White gains space, supports b4, and may keep the center fluid. 4. Compare the benefits of ...Nc6 pressure with ...Nbd7 flexibility before selecting a repertoire branch. 5. Mixing the plans can place both knights on passive squares.

BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 14 plies from memory, then replay: 5. Nf3 O-O 6. Be2 e5 7. O-O Nbd7

PLAY PASS | PLAN EXECUTION AND TACTICAL CONTACT

Play: The quieter Orthodox route



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

...Nbd7 avoids an immediate commitment of the queen knight and supports ...c6, though it gives different pressure than ...Nc6.

DECISION RULE

Compare the benefits of ...Nc6 pressure with ...Nbd7 flexibility before selecting a repertoire branch.

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S JOB

Prepare a central challenge and keep the rook useful on e8.

WHITE'S COUNTERPLAY

White gains space, supports b4, and may keep the center fluid.

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CUE

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FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

White

WHITE'S BEST PRACTICAL IDEA

White gains space, supports b4, and may keep the center fluid.

FAILURE MODE

Mixing the plans can place both knights on passive squares.

DECISION TEST

Ask: Compare the benefits of ...Nc6 pressure with ...Nbd7 flexibility before selecting a repertoire branch. Then compare at least two candidates against White's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

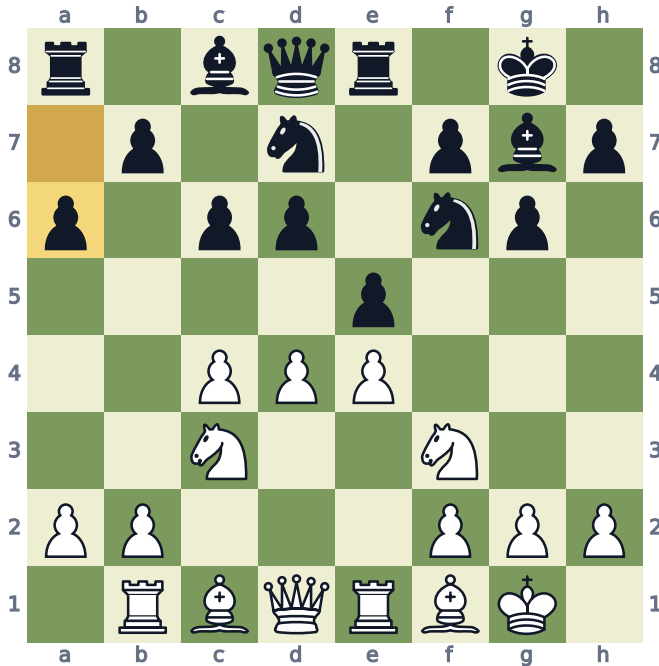
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INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 g6 3. Nc3 Bg7 4. e4 d6 5. Nf3 O-O 6. Be2 e5 7. O-O Nbd7 8. Re1 c6 9. Bf1 Re8 10. Rb1 a6



- Re1: White places a rook on a line expected to open or uses it to support a central transformation.
- c6: Black changes the pawn skeleton; reassess breaks, open lines, and weakened squares.
- Bf1: White changes a bishop's diagonal and the balance between development, pressure, and tempo.
- Re8: Black places a rook on a line expected to open or uses it to support a central transformation.
- Rb1: White places a rook on a line expected to open or uses it to support a central transformation.
- a6: Black changes the pawn skeleton; reassess breaks, open lines, and weakened squares.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

...Nbd7 avoids an immediate commitment of the queen knight and supports ...c6, though it gives different pressure than ...Nc6.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

Compare the benefits of ...Nc6 pressure with ...Nbd7 flexibility before selecting a repertoire branch. White's resistance is: White gains space, supports b4, and may keep the center fluid. The line fails as a template when: Mixing the plans can place both knights on passive squares.

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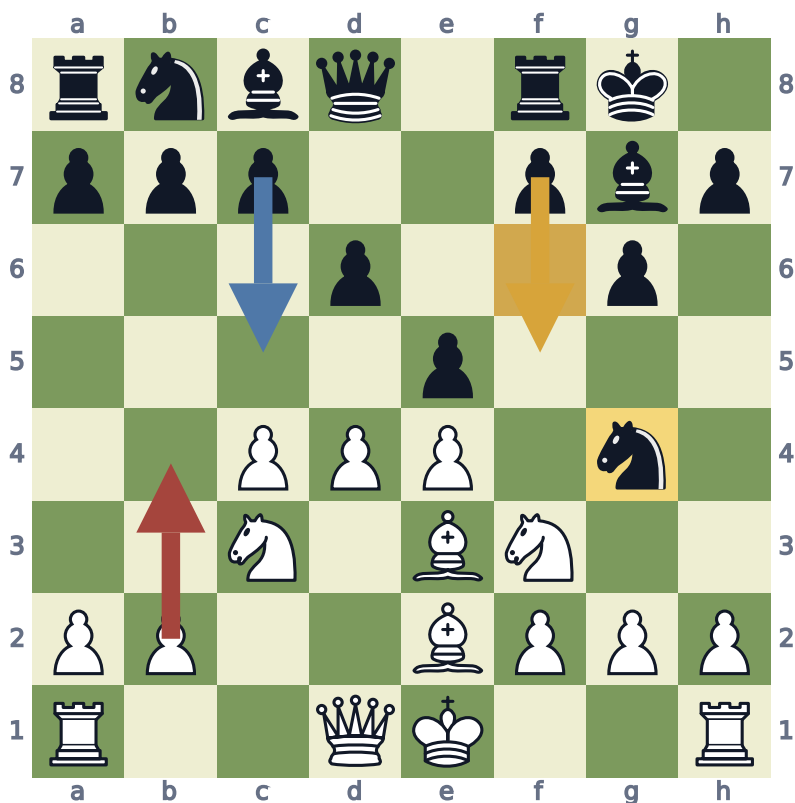
1. ...Nbd7 avoids an immediate commitment of the queen knight and supports ...c6, though it gives different pressure than ...Nc6. 2. Prepare a central challenge and keep the rook useful on e8. 3. White gains space, supports b4, and may keep the center fluid. 4. Compare the benefits of ...Nc6 pressure with ...Nbd7 flexibility before selecting a repertoire branch. 5. Mixing the plans can place both knights on passive squares.

BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 20 plies from memory, then replay: 8. Re1 c6 9. Bf1 Re8 10. Rb1 a6

DECODE PASS | STRUCTURAL DECISION POINT

Decode: Gligoric's Be3 question



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

White develops the bishop before castling and asks Black to reveal the kingside structure.

DECISION RULE

Before ...g5 calculate whether the center is closed enough and whether h5 becomes a weakness.

SIDE TO MOVE

White

BLACK'S JOB

Gain time on the bishop, control f4, and decide whether the space gained by ...g5 is worth the dark-square cost.

WHITE'S COUNTERPLAY

White wants d5, Qd2, and queenside castling or a stable central edge.

MEMORY RULE | A tempo gain is real only when the pawn weaknesses are affordable.

CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

The plan map



CUE

White develops the bishop before castling and asks Black to reveal the kingside structure.

BLACK AIMS FOR

Gain time on the bishop, control f4, and decide whether the space gained by ...g5 is worth the dark-square cost.

FINAL SIDE TO MOVE

White

WHITE'S BEST PRACTICAL IDEA

White wants d5, Qd2, and queenside castling or a stable central edge.

FAILURE MODE

Chasing the bishop without central safety can expose Black's own king.

DECISION TEST

Ask: Before ...g5 calculate whether the center is closed enough and whether h5 becomes a weakness. Then compare at least two candidates against White's strongest forcing reply. Choose the endpoint whose center, king safety, and piece jobs you can explain.

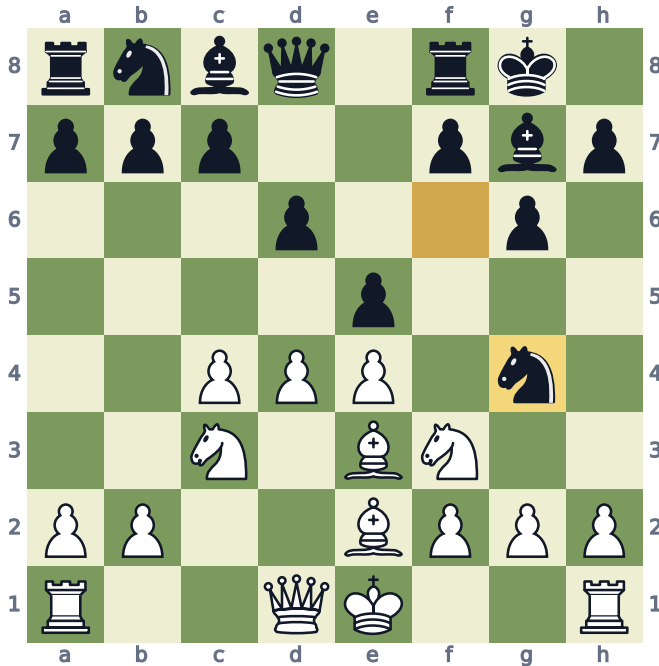
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INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 g6 3. Nc3 Bg7 4. e4 d6 5. Nf3 O-O 6. Be2 e5 7. Be3 Ng4 8. Bg5 f6 9. Bh4 g5 10. Bg3 Nh6



- Nf3: White reroutes a knight toward f3; judge the move by its next square and immediate job.
- O-O: Black secures the king and activates a rook; the central decision can now become concrete.
- Be2: White changes a bishop's diagonal and the balance between development, pressure, and tempo.
- e5: Black makes direct central contact and asks whether White will close, capture, or maintain tension.
- Be3: White changes a bishop's diagonal and the balance between development, pressure, and tempo.
- Ng4: Black reroutes a knight toward g4; judge the move by its next square and immediate job.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

White develops the bishop before castling and asks Black to reveal the kingside structure.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

Before ...g5 calculate whether the center is closed enough and whether h5 becomes a weakness. White's resistance is: White wants d5, Qd2, and queenside castling or a stable central edge. The line fails as a template when: Chasing the bishop without central safety can expose Black's own king.

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Retrieval and self-coaching

1. What center or structural transition defines this position?

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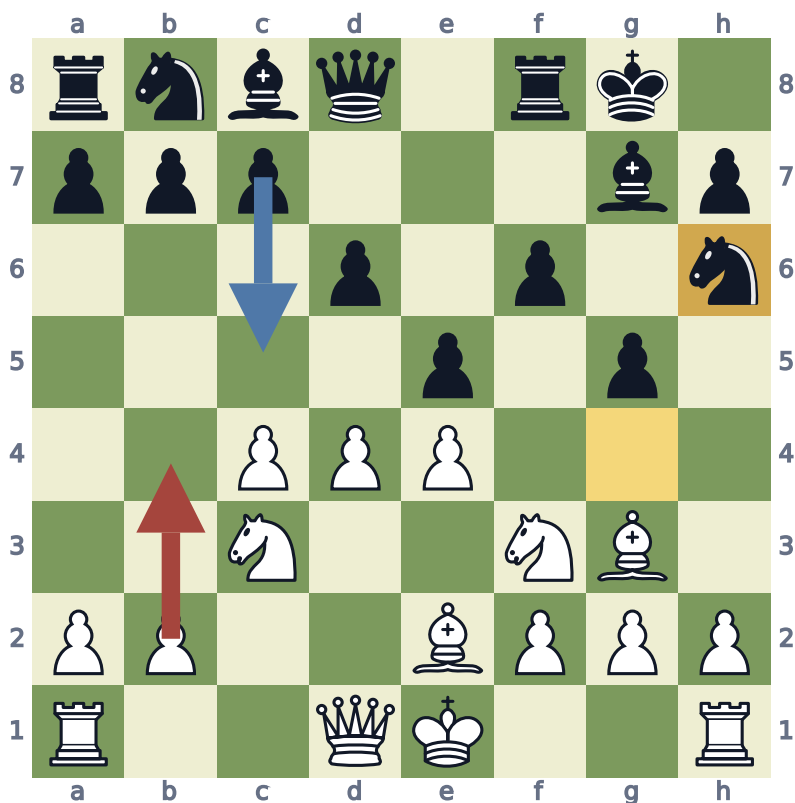
1. White develops the bishop before castling and asks Black to reveal the kingside structure. 2. Gain time on the bishop, control f4, and decide whether the space gained by ...g5 is worth the dark-square cost. 3. White wants d5, Qd2, and queenside castling or a stable central edge. 4. Before ...g5 calculate whether the center is closed enough and whether h5 becomes a weakness. 5. Chasing the bishop without central safety can expose Black's own king.

BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 14 plies from memory, then replay: 5. Nf3 O-O 6. Be2 e5 7. Be3 Ng4

PLAY PASS | PLAN EXECUTION AND TACTICAL CONTACT

Play: Gligoric's Be3 question



WHY THIS POSITION MATTERS

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SIDE TO MOVE

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CUE -> REASON -> MOVE -> REPLY -> NEW POSITION

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CUE

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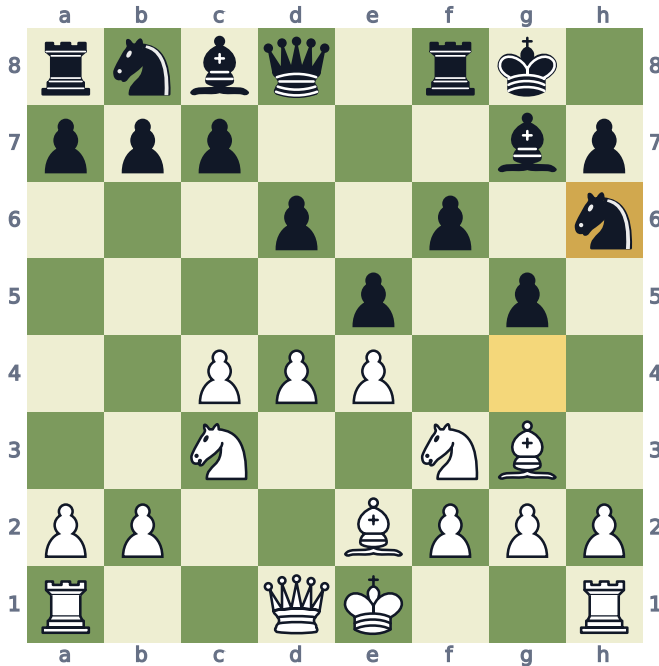
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INSTRUCTIVE REFERENCE LINE - NOT A PROMISE OF FORCED BEST PLAY

Move-by-move meaning

REFERENCE LINE

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- Bg5: White changes a bishop's diagonal and the balance between development, pressure, and tempo.
- f6: Black changes the pawn skeleton; reassess breaks, open lines, and weakened squares.
- Bh4: White changes a bishop's diagonal and the balance between development, pressure, and tempo.
- g5: Black gains or fixes kingside space and prepares line-opening contact for the pieces.
- Bg3: White changes a bishop's diagonal and the balance between development, pressure, and tempo.
- Nh6: Black reroutes a knight toward h6; judge the move by its next square and immediate job.

WHAT THE LINE TEACHES

White develops the bishop before castling and asks Black to reveal the kingside structure.

WHAT MUST BE CALCULATED

Before ...g5 calculate whether the center is closed enough and whether h5 becomes a weakness. White's resistance is: White wants d5, Qd2, and queenside castling or a stable central edge. The line fails as a template when: Chasing the bishop without central safety can expose Black's own king.

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ANSWER KEY

1. White develops the bishop before castling and asks Black to reveal the kingside structure. 2. Gain time on the bishop, control f4, and decide whether the space gained by ...g5 is worth the dark-square cost. 3. White wants d5, Qd2, and queenside castling or a stable central edge. 4. Before ...g5 calculate whether the center is closed enough and whether h5 becomes a weakness. 5. Chasing the bishop without central safety can expose Black's own king.

BOARD RECONSTRUCTION

Rebuild the position after 20 plies from memory, then replay: 8. Bg5 f6 9. Bh4 g5 10. Bg3 Nh6

SIX-POSITION TEST

Can you retrieve the plan without the chapter?

LESSON 013 Decode: Main-line entry

Prompt: On move nine identify White's setup before choosing ...Nd7, ...Nh5, ...a5, or another preparation.

Recall: The branch is identified by White's first queenside commitment.

LESSON 014 Play: Main-line entry

Prompt: On move nine identify White's setup before choosing ...Nd7, ...Nh5, ...a5, or another preparation.

Recall: The branch is identified by White's first queenside commitment.

LESSON 015 Decode: The quieter Orthodox route

Prompt: Compare the benefits of ...Nc6 pressure with ...Nbd7 flexibility before selecting a repertoire branch.

Recall: A move order is a package of piece routes, not a cosmetic choice.

LESSON 016 Play: The quieter Orthodox route

Prompt: Compare the benefits of ...Nc6 pressure with ...Nbd7 flexibility before selecting a repertoire branch.

Recall: A move order is a package of piece routes, not a cosmetic choice.

LESSON 017 Decode: Gligoric's Be3 question

Prompt: Before ...g5 calculate whether the center is closed enough and whether h5 becomes a weakness.

Recall: A tempo gain is real only when the pawn weaknesses are affordable.

LESSON 018 Play: Gligoric's Be3 question

Prompt: Before ...g5 calculate whether the center is closed enough and whether h5 becomes a weakness.

Recall: A tempo gain is real only when the pawn weaknesses are affordable.

PASS STANDARD

For each position: name the structure, Black's plan, White's counterplay, one candidate, the strongest reply, and the failure mode. Score one point each; 30 of 36 is a pass.

THREE SCENARIOS TO STORE

One-page repertoire memory sheet

CARD 1

Main-line entry

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 g6 3. Nc3 Bg7 4. e4 d6 5. Nf3 O-O 6. Be2 e5 7. O-O Nc6 8. d5 Ne7

Decision: On move nine identify White's setup before choosing ...Nd7, ...Nh5, ...a5, or another preparation.

Memory: The branch is identified by White's first queenside commitment.

CARD 2

The quieter Orthodox route

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 g6 3. Nc3 Bg7 4. e4 d6 5. Nf3 O-O 6. Be2 e5 7. O-O Nbd7 8. Re1 c6 9. Bf1 Re8 10. Rb1 a6

Decision: Compare the benefits of ...Nc6 pressure with ...Nbd7 flexibility before selecting a repertoire branch.

Memory: A move order is a package of piece routes, not a cosmetic choice.

CARD 3

Gligoric's Be3 question

1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 g6 3. Nc3 Bg7 4. e4 d6 5. Nf3 O-O 6. Be2 e5 7. Be3 Ng4 8. Bg5 f6 9. Bh4 g5 10. Bg3 Nh6

Decision: Before ...g5 calculate whether the center is closed enough and whether h5 becomes a weakness.

Memory: A tempo gain is real only when the pawn weaknesses are affordable.

Reconstruct each card from the final position, then from the opening moves alone.

SPACED RETRIEVAL AND GAME TRANSFER

Volume mastery tracker

Lesson	D1	D3	D7	D14	D30	Game	Pass
013 Decode: Main-line entry	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
014 Play: Main-line entry	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
015 Decode: The quieter Orthodox route	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
016 Play: The quieter Orthodox route	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
017 Decode: Gligoric's Be3 question	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
018 Play: Gligoric's Be3 question	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

TWELVE-WEEK CYCLE

Weeks 1-2: decode the three structures. Weeks 3-4: replay all lines from memory. Weeks 5-7: solve the workbook pages. Weeks 8-10: test in slow games or against Fritz. Weeks 11-12: analyze failures and retest the volume examination.

PROMOTION RULE

Advance only when you can explain every memory rule, reproduce the three reference lines, name White's best counterplay, and show at least one analyzed game where the decision appeared.

Do not measure mastery by pages completed. Measure whether the correct questions appear during a real game.